

Episode 50: Once Upon a Time... (32) – Pentel Name Pens Going "Shuko Shuko!" *Crying Freeman* Appears!

How did everyone spend Golden Week? I was all about zoos! (laugh)

First to Ueno Zoo. Then to Asahiyama Zoo in Asahikawa, Hokkaido.

Actually, I had never seen a real panda in my entire life. Despite being born and raised in Tokyo, I had never been to Ueno Zoo. This time I went after hearing about Linlin's death, so I couldn't meet him in the end, but I joined my hands in prayer in front of the panda house where his portrait was displayed.

Asahiyama Zoo was also my first time. On the night of the 2nd, I suddenly had a flash of "I want to eat Genghis Khan!" so I arranged airline tickets on the web and went to Sapporo on the 3rd. Then I had another flash and extended my trip to Asahikawa on the 4th.

Man, zoos are great. You know, everyone's smiling—the visitors. Not just children, but adults are all smiling too, and no matter how crowded it gets, there's something mysteriously calming about it. It's real animal power. After all, having elephants, lions, giraffes, tigers—even with fences and cages, having the real thing right in front of you moving around is amazing. Pure amazement. It was incredibly fun (laugh).

But you know, the animals entertaining all of us—most of them are just one or two individuals. Especially with larger animals, the fewer the number kept. Well, it can't be helped, but living forever in a place without friends—or rather, without fellow species members—feels somehow poignant. Thinking about that deceased panda being alone for so long in his old age makes me think he must have been lonely.

Still, the penguins at Asahiyama Zoo—man, they're divine! So cute! Penguins have such different individual personalities, and they're so lively. There are even clingy ones (laugh).

Anyway, seeing so many animals up close like that might have been a first. It was good mood-changing and spiritual nutrition replenishment! (laugh)

Well then.

Finally it has come—OVA *Crying Freeman*. An OVA work based on the gekiga by original creators Koike Kazuo and Ikegami Ryoichi. I participated in two *Freeman* works over two years.

First was *Crying Freeman 4: Yugekitougoku* (雄首冬獄). Script by Ono Ryunosuke, animation director Urushihara Satoshi, art director Nakamura Mitsuki.

Then *Crying Freeman 5: Senjou no Kishimojin* (戦場の鬼子母神). Script by Ono Ryunosuke, animation director Yamashita Takaaki, art directors Nakamura Mitsuki and Yoshida Noboru.

Both were directed by Yamauchi Shigeyasu. Participating in director Yamauchi's work again after a long time. And once again, thoroughly realistic direction. This *Freeman* had already had three productions made, all with other people handling colour direction. So I did the fourth and fifth. I think director Yamauchi brought me in.

"Don't worry about the 'colours' from previous works—first try thinking freely in Tsujita-kun's way," said the director. Actually, for these two works, character design was entrusted to me from the beginning (perhaps because of that, the ending credits were actually "Colour Design & Inspection").

Even so, since these were works with originals, basically the original colour prints were the major premise, and it would be problematic if they changed too much from the

existing three works. Worrying about this in my own way, I submitted several initial designs each. Then, as usual, the director and everyone gathered to check, but absolutely everything got corrections, almost total annihilation. Complete restart from the beginning.

The direction the director wanted was more realistic while having "flair." The colours I first submitted had probed too much for realism, all becoming similarly subdued and too biased. So we repeated correction, check, correction. The director himself seemed to think "hmm" when seeing my colour samples, and through repeating these corrections, the director's image and everyone's basic worldview gradually solidified. Incidentally, this work process—or trial and error—was the same not just for "4: Yugekitougoku" but also "5: Senjou no Kishimojin."

Both 4: *Yugekitougoku* and 5: *Senjou no Kishimojin* had art by Nakamura-san's Office Mec-Man. Sometimes delicate, sometimes rough, these Mec-Man backgrounds had a really good atmosphere that fit this work. Particularly in "5: Senjou no Kishimojin," animation director Yamashita-san drew layouts for almost every single cut densely without a single gap, creating another masterpiece of completion (laugh). Art director Yoshida-san, confronted with this, responded with an equally detailed and dense frontal assault—a wonderful battle unfolded. Being pulled along by both, tension kept rising and it became a good work.

For colour direction, while still having paint problems, I was gradually getting used to realistic works, and I gradually developed my own methodology for realistic, subdued colour usage. Special colouring matched to scene backgrounds also became reasonably well-balanced screens when going in dark directions. But now special colouring that removed saturation while going in bright directions became a bottleneck (bitter laugh). While thinking there were still limits, special effects staff helped me out with various impossible requests.

Not just colour direction but finishing-wise, the most difficult struggle was this "gekiga style" artistic style. Like the original art style, "realistic line touches" were drawn into

every cut, every character, every animation frame in the animation. This was extremely difficult for finishing.

In animation cel finishing, pencil lines drawn on animation are carbon-transferred to animation cels using a machine called a trace machine, but this didn't transfer well. It often became uneven, and the uneven density of those realistic touch lines created flickering. Correcting this was incredibly difficult (bitter laugh). Using the oil-based marker "Pentel Name Pen" often used for cel line correction, we endlessly hand-corrected. We corrected in finishing, then at rushes the assistant director and even the animation director himself corrected like crazy with marker pens going "shuko shuko" (bitter laugh).

Furthermore, with detailed art styles and intricate shadows and highlights, it was a parade of colouring mistakes and colour flickers (crying). In the end we couldn't fix everything, leaving many embarrassing retakes in the main story.

This *Freeman*, with gekiga-style realistic art featuring lots of weapons and firearms, realistic depictions, plus plenty of "adult scenes"—it's a work that boys would admire a bit (laugh). Being a boy myself, weapons and firearms were endlessly interesting. And "adult scenes" were even more interesting (laugh).

But even with such scenes, it wasn't so-called "18+ anime," and since they were necessary scenes within the story, it was important to make them naturally beautiful scenes within the flow. We couldn't go too far into "erotic" realism. That area was very delicate. So especially visually, parts that shouldn't be shown all became silhouette colouring or black fills.

Actually, there was a small incident during production. There was a cut where a female character fought completely nude. This cut was outsourced to an overseas production for animation and finishing work, but amazingly, "pubic hair" not drawn in the key animation or animation director corrections was properly drawn and came back as cels. Three or four such cuts! My goodness, what a surprise (laugh). I don't know why this

happened, but the animator probably "serviced" us by drawing it (laugh). Naturally this couldn't be used, so we had to redraw all those animation parts and re-finish (bitter laugh).

4: *Yugekitougoku* and 5: *Senjou no Kishimojin* were completed through all this. 1991-autumn 1992.

I recently rewatched these two works after a long time. My, how nostalgic (laugh). At the same time, I thought "Ah, I want to remake this with today's digital technology." If possible, I want to redo at least all the cels from colour direction up. That's how wonderful the animation and art are. Ah, wouldn't someone make this *Crying Freeman* again? (laugh).

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